further on… [for] a more philosophical and transcendental idea.' That idea Radhakrishnan expressed in almost poetic terms: 'The cure for error is not the stake or the cudgel, not force or persecution, but the quiet diffusion of light.'[17]

Radhakrishnan spoke as a professor of philosophy; Vivekananda declaimed as a preacher; but their message was the same, rendering the Hinduism of Advaita Vedanta comprehensible to the modern Western mind. It was, however, the charismatic Swami who had the more lasting impact. Vivekananda's overt respect for all other paths and religions was an integral part of what he preached. Part of his appeal lay in the way he combined ancient wisdom with contemporary insights, in spreading his profound message of interfaith harmony and spirituality married to rationalism.

Vivekananda had quoted the Bhagavad Gita to the effect that 'Whosoever comes to me, through whatsoever form, I reach him; all men are struggling through paths which in the end lead to me.' Vivekananda went on to denounce the fact that 'sectarianism, bigotry, and its horrible descendant, fanaticism, have long possessed this beautiful earth. They have filled the earth with violence, and drenched it often with human blood, destroyed civilisation, and sent whole nations to despair'.

His confident belief that the death-knell of these negative forces had been sounded was sadly not to be borne out. But his vision—summarised in the Sanskrit credo '*sarva dharma sambhava*'—all religions are equally worthy of respect—is, in fact, the kind of Hinduism practised by most of India's Hindus, whose instinctive acceptance of other faiths and forms of worship has long been the distinctive hallmark of Indianness, not merely in a narrow religious sense, but in a broader cultural and spiritual sense too.

The efforts of Swami Vivekananda and the other Hindu reformers and thinkers served to reassert their faith in the face of the racist notions of Christian superiority peddled by the colonial rulers. Far from the religion of superstitious idol-worshippers caricatured by the imperialists, they demonstrated that Hinduism was sophisticated, monotheistic and inclusive. It was a faith that had undergone several reformations and absorbed them all; the incorporation of Buddhist ideas, for instance, had